the harem, Padshah Begum, in recognition of her sacrifice for her family. There were many widows, divorced women, and homeless Timurid women who were all part of the Mughal harem. Babur had sent to all these women a letter which was both invitation and imploration, offering them a place of safety in Hindustan after the destruction of the Timurid homeland by the Uzbeks, but also asking for their help in maintaining the precious Timurid legacy in this new country. The matriarchs of the Mughal Empire, mothers, widows, and grandaunts, would continue to be revered figures of authority and love through the many turbulent generations. This was why, despite the determined effort to keep the royal women nameless and faceless, Gulbadan and her sisters in the harem escaped the cloister of Fatehpur Sikri and the pardeh-giyan were never truly invisible.

Other noteworthy incidents in this period involved two of Akbar's favourite people. In faraway Naples, in the summer of 1583, the Duke of Atri was in a joyous mood. 'He ordered his household to dress in their holiday suits of white, and welcomed the news with illuminations, fire-works, and all the state which he could display.' The news that he was celebrating was the long-awaited martyrdom of his fifth son, Rudolf Acquaviva, at the age of thirty-three. After surviving the Mughal court, despite his public and profane desecration of the Prophet, Acquaviva found martyrdom when he was least expecting it, among the 'heathens'. The Jesuit, along with four companions, was hacked to death by a mob of Hindus whom they had been trying to convert, in Salcette, south of Goa. 'He gladly stretched out his neck,' averred Monserrate, 'and offered his throat to the savages who slew him'. Akbar greeted the news of the death of his young friend with vivid sorrow: 'Alas, Father! Did I not tell you not to go away? But you would not listen to me.'

The artist Daswant, too, would die in 1583, stabbed by his own hand, overcome by melancholy. But others would take his place, and Akbar's taswir khana would create works of beauty whose legacy would long outlive the mortal painters, many of whom would remain anonymous and largely forgotten.